and expanding her remit. Her current responsibilities connect commercial discipline with execution. In a business where orders can involve complex defence systems and long delivery cycles, winning work is only one part of the task. The company must also execute orders while protecting margins. Choudari says Zen does not want to take business at a loss. For both women, leadership has meant moving beyond a functional job description and understanding how different parts of a business fit together and ensuring that decisions translate into execution.

BUILDING THE INSTITUTIONAL MUSCLE

For Garuda Aerospace's Mohan, the challenge was to transition from start-up to scale-up. If an employee's absence or departure causes a task to stall, the organisation has not yet built a sufficiently robust system. Her response was to create processes that make people less dependent on managers while remaining accountable for outcomes. The objective is not to eliminate initiative. It is to build an organisation where initiative can flourish without every decision needing the founder's intervention. "One thing I've learnt is that you cannot wait for someone to give you authority. You have to own it," says Mohan. This has particular significance in aerospace and defence, sectors where technical expertise and established hierarchies can make it harder for a woman leader to be taken seriously. Mohan says she prepares, asks questions and examines details rather than assuming that authority will automatically follow her designation. Her ambition is institutional. She wants Garuda to become less dependent on any one person, including herself. That requires clarifying responsibilities, building accountability and giving teams room to make decisions.

At Pronto, Sardana's challenge is different. The business is trying to formalise services delivered through a largely informal workforce. Her ambition reaches beyond household services to other physical-work sectors, including warehouses, factories, manufacturing and retail. She sees India's large workforce as an opportunity to develop capabilities around AI and robotics in the physical world.

Her willingness to enter a market she did not fully understand is central to her story. But conviction alone cannot sustain a business. As the company grows, the task is to translate that conviction into reliable service delivery, effective worker support and repeatable operations.



ACCORDING TO A SURVEY, 28% BELIEVE THE EVALUATION PROCESS IS GENUINELY FAIR AND TRANSPARENT

AUTHORITY, CREDIBILITY

Not all of these leaders describe gender as defining their careers. Their experiences, however, reveal different ways in which women negotiate authority.

Rangarajan says she did not want to rely on being the managing director's wife or a board member to establish her place at Data Patterns. She had to build credibility with employees who had worked alongside her husband from the early years of the company. Her approach was to work with them, take responsibility and demonstrate what needed to change. She also articulates a broader concern about professional advancement: "Men are always recruited for potential. Women have to prove it. Women are recruited with proof."

Rangarajan 's experience suggests credibility can be built through performance, but it also raises the question of why women may have to demonstrate readiness so visibly in the first place.